

Mannerism

Mannerism describes the approach of certain architects who pushed the limits of accepted Renaissance styles, often featuring exaggerated proportions and inventive blends of elements. For some Mannerists this approach came from an incomplete understanding of classical proportions; others knew them well but chose to override them. Michelangelo, one of the latter, became the best-known architect associated with the style. His Biblioteca Laurenziana (1524–71) in Florence, for instance, expressed his forceful, imaginative and revolutionary ideas about space and proportion. Similarly, his designs for St Peter's in Rome were inspired by, but contrasted with, the classical ideas favoured at the time.

Mannerism was not confined to Italy. The El Escorial Palace near Madrid, for instance, designed by Juan Bautista de Toledo (c.1515–67), who had worked on St Peter's, and completed in 1584 by his apprentice, Juan de Herrera (1530–97), is Mannerist in its simplicity and severity (opposite).

